Sherif Abaza

Director of Events | Flagship Conferences, Summits and Large-Scale Event Production

Valkenswaard, Netherlands (open to relocation to Santa Clara, CA; available for 60% domestic and international travel) | +31 6 2306 3073 | sabaza@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/sabaza

SUMMARY

Events director with 20+ years of event management experience and 15+ years leading teams and businesses. I founded and led **Sphere Events** to a **140-person, USD 8M+ business** delivering **150+ events a year**: multi-day conferences, innovation fairs, executive forums and festival franchises for clients including **Siemens, Ericsson, Porsche, Cartier and Emaar**. I have led delivery of client programmes at **three consecutive UN climate summits (COP27, COP28, COP29)**, multi-day events of 40,000+ delegates combining keynote plenaries, breakout sessions, exhibition pavilions, networking and heads-of-state programmes.

I own flagship events end to end, as the single point of strategic and operational accountability. I define goals, structure and success metrics with senior leadership, build the master timeline, negotiate venues, lead agencies and production vendors across staging, A/V, broadcast and on-site logistics, and hold the budget and forecast through to post-event evaluation. Eight years on the executive team at Withlocals taught me how to align business units, make the case for investment to leadership and build agreement quickly across functions. AI is part of how I work every day, including two products I have designed and shipped through AI coding agents.

CORE SKILLS

- Flagship event strategy, goals and success metrics
- Large-scale, multi-day conferences and summits
- Keynotes, breakouts, exhibitions and networking
- Multi-million budget ownership and forecasting
- Staging, A/V, broadcast and technical production
- Venue sourcing and venue negotiations
- Agency, vendor and venue relationship management
- Master event timelines and workstream planning
- Primary executive point of contact, C-suite reporting
- Cross-functional alignment across business units
- Creative and experiential vision with brand teams
- Post-event evaluation and business impact
- Heads-of-state, executive and VVIP programmes
- AI-led event planning and ways of working

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Abaza Business Services · Netherlands / Global

Founder & Managing Director; Events Director and Technical Director (engagements) | 2019 – Present

- Led end-to-end delivery of client programmes at **COP27 (Egypt), COP28 (UAE) and COP29 (Azerbaijan)**: pavilions, side events and sessions for heads-of-state, ministerial and senior stakeholder groups and global media, leading multinational teams, master timelines and on-site logistics.
- Event portfolio advisor to **Barry Callebaut**: built the budget and benchmarking case for leadership across its global events, identifying around **€711K in savings** across two 2025 events, and advising on World Chocolate Masters 2026 and a **CHF 1M** leadership meeting.
- Events Director and Technical Director for global experiential agencies **Jack Morton, Shelton Fleming and Impact XM**, leading staging, A/V, venue and vendor teams in-market and holding partners to the agencies' quality standards.
- Event programme strategy for **NBA** market-entry initiatives in Europe and Africa, working with senior league stakeholders.

Sphere Events and Communication · Dubai, UAE

Founder & Managing Director | 2008 – 2018

- Founded and led the company for ten years, growing it from a sole operator to **140 people and USD 8M+** in annual revenue, with full P&L accountability for a portfolio of **150+ events a year and 800+ in total**.
- Strategic events partner to **Siemens, Ericsson, Porsche, Cartier and Emaar**, delivering multi-day conferences, innovation fairs and executive forums from concept and creative direction through on-site delivery and reporting.
- Ran production end to end: staging and rigging, sound and lighting, LED and screens, power, broadcast and live streaming, and technical rehearsals, with production, technical, front-of-house and volunteer crews working to a single run-of-show.
- Built original event properties, **Street Nights, Marina Music Festival and Dubai Chocolate Festival**, into recurring franchises with their own sponsors and public-sector partners, raising scale and production quality edition after edition for audiences of tens of thousands.

- Expanded into sport and gaming, including the **KitKat 3x3 basketball tournament** and **esports tournaments** with broadcast production and sponsor integration.
- Built the operational playbooks, supplier frameworks and QA processes that kept quality consistent across formats and markets.

Withlocals B.V. · Eindhoven, Netherlands
Chief Community Officer | 2022 – 2026
Chief Growth Officer | 2018 – 2022

- Member of the executive team for eight years, aligning product, marketing, operations and commercial teams behind company priorities.
- Set the growth strategy and market priorities that took the company from 50 to **300+ cities in 80+ countries**.
- Created the **B2B partnership business**: commercial model, deal structure and multi-year retention of enterprise accounts.
- Led the company's pivot to virtual experiences, winning **70+ corporate clients in under 90 days** with zero ad spend.
- Set community strategy for a **2,000+ partner network** across 80+ countries.

FrontFlip (me360) · Kansas City, USA / MENA
CEO, Middle East & North Africa | 2010 – 2015

- Led the regional business with full P&L ownership. **Raised USD 1.8M** and built a 35-person team across 6+ markets.

Sundance Events · Dubai, UAE
Business Development & Operations Manager | 2006 – 2008

- Built the client base and partner network for corporate and government event accounts.

ASDAA Burson-Marsteller · Dubai, UAE
Senior Account Manager | 2004 – 2006

- Communications strategy for Siemens, Adidas and Hilton across the Middle East. Key role producing the **inaugural Dubai International Film Festival**.

AI PROJECTS

- **The Vault (myvaults.io)**: a collectibles management app with AI card identification, designed and shipped by me through AI coding agents.
- **Cards of Kaladan**: a digital card game in closed Android beta, built the same way.
- In event work I use AI for RFP and budget analysis, supplier comparisons, run-of-show and brief drafts, and multilingual attendee communications.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Computer Engineering
Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport, Alexandria, Egypt

LEADERSHIP

AIESEC International
Local Committee President; National Support Team | 1999 – 2004

LANGUAGES

Arabic (native), English (native), French (excellent), Spanish (excellent), Dutch (working), Polish (working), Portuguese, Italian and Romanian (basic)

WORK AUTHORISATION

Dutch (EU) citizen